



Forest Management (JFM), the buzzword among forest authorities in the 1990s, has met a similar fate. Enshrined in the National Forest Policy 1988, the idea came into force in 1994, with the World Bank bankrolling it for the constitution of village forest committees, forest protection committees and eco-development committees. It, however, abruptly dropped the project in 2000. Following an outcry, the committees have been largely confined to paper. "A meagre sum of Rs 840 is deposited monthly in the forest protection committee's account for the payment of the chowkidar," says its president Madan Pawar in Jhunkar village of Hoshangabad district.

In effect, these committees have only served to employ chowkidars at rates lower than the Government's minimum wages. Preventing deforestation is also impossible because it sours social ties. Reports suggest that

hectares of forest land, of which Meena wrested 40,000 back.

As of now, the state has 14,073 village forest committees, protection committees and eco-development committees on paper. In reality, most are floundering. After the withdrawal of World Bank, the village forest committees that aimed to improve degraded forests have had little to do. As for the failure of eco-development committees in protecting wildlife, Panna is the biggest and latest example where not one of the 26 such committees raised a voice on the dwindling number of tigers in the reserve.

For Madhya Pradesh, forest management is crucial and the related problems acute—of the 52,739 villages, 22,600 are located in or near forest areas. Most of the villagers live off the forests and the economy of about 95 lakh tribals is also inextricably linked with them.



A HAPLESS BHIMRAO AND SHANTA (FAR LEFT); MEMBERS OF JHUNKAR VILLAGE FOREST COMMITTEE

in many cases the committee members have themselves been involved in encroachment on forest land and illegal felling. Says Sunil, a local activist, "When massive felling of trees was taking place in forests of Budhni forest range in 2007 and 2008, not a single committee reported the cases even once." There have been some exceptions as well. Officials like former Burhanpur DFO Mohan Meena have been penalised with transfers on resisting political pressure to disband corrupt committees. The reason, in particular, was a 2003 case involving committees of 22 villages and encroachment on almost 50,000

The mounting demand on forest resources on the one hand and biotic pressure on the forests on the other, have split peoples' groups and environmentalists right down the middle. Anurag Modi of Shramik Adivasi Sangathan in Harda and Betul argues for absolute restoration of the traditional rights of the tribals on forest lands. There are noted environmentalists, on the other hand, like planner M.N. Buch, who are against any more tampering with forests. Foresters aren't helping matters either by their acts of omission and commission.

With the stakes so huge, solutions are perhaps not that easy to find. ■